Life in the Circus

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The smell of animals, incense, and burning pitch fills the air. Murmurs of excitement punctuate the dark, open space. From outside, silver light cast by a crescent moon slices through the tent's entryway. Suddenly, music bursts in from all sides. The curtain rises, spotlights flood the ring in the middle of the tent, and a lone figure standing in the center spurs the crowd's cacophonous applause. "Welcome, welcome!" the figure booms. "Welcome to the greatest show on Golarion!"

At the start of this adventure, the PCs inherit the Circus of Wayward Wonders, and they're thrust into the roles of showrunners in addition to their responsibilities as adventurers. Throughout the Extinction Curse Adventure Path, the PCs will travel all over the Isle of Erran and the Isle of Kortos, undertaking a grand adventure to save the land from an ancient evil. Thankfully, it's not all dire omens and life-or-death circumstances—during their off time, the PCs can unwind by running a joyous circus where the worst case scenario is a comically clumsy show. To ensure their circus is a success, the PCs will need to promote, orchestrate, and execute fantastic shows in towns big and small.

The rules in this article are designed to give the PCs agency over their circus and approximate the fun and responsibility of running a traveling troupe of entertainers. While intended for use throughout the Extinction Curse Adventure Path, the rules are flexible enough to be used in any campaign.

Running a Circus

Throughout the Extinction Curse Adventure Path, the Circus of Wayward Wonders will travel from the Isle of Erran to the Isle of Kortos, where the PCs' adventure to protect the *aeon orbs* will take them to a variety of settlements and locales across the island. While their circus might play into their main adventure to varying degrees, the rules in this article give the players the ability to manage their troupe in the abstract and focus in on specific shows as they like. (An outline of the Extinction Curse Adventure Path can be found on page 73.)

CIRCUS BASICS

The PCs' management of their circus is separated into two parts: downtime, during which the PCs prepare for their show by promoting their circus and purchasing advertisements or circus upgrades; and the night of the big show, when the PCs actively take part in the grand performance or otherwise ensure their circus's show is a success.

During downtime, the PCs must generate Anticipation in order to draw a sizable crowd to their circus show. In order to drum up Anticipation, the PCs can purchase advertisements or Promote the Circus using a special downtime activity. The circus's Prestige and random variables also determine a show's starting Anticipation.

Up to once per week, the PCs can put on a circus show, which takes place in encounter mode. During the performance, the PCs and their chosen NPC performers perform in four acts to generate Excitement. To complete an act, the PCs choose which tricks—circus parlance for a particular stunt or performance—to put on during the act, the performers then attempt the appropriate trick checks to determine the success of each trick. A trick's level determines how much Excitement each of its trick checks generates. In addition, random variables beyond the PCs' control can affect their performances, making it impossible to fully predict the outcome of any one show.

The players can track the progress of each circus show, including Anticipation, Excitement, and the outcome of tricks and acts, using a copy of the Circus Show Sheet on page 68. At the end of the show, if the PCs generated more Excitement than Anticipation, they earn their full Payout—an amount of money determined by the show's final Anticipation and the circus's Prestige. The party can spend this Payout to upgrade their circus facilities, purchase advertisements for future shows, and hire more performers.

Terminology

Below are the key terms used in these circus rules.

Acts: Every circus show is broken up into four acts, each of which consists of one or more tricks: the opener (one trick), the build-up (two tricks), the big number (one trick), and the finale (three tricks).

Advertisements: The PCs can pay for criers, newspaper listings, and signage either mundane or magical to build up Anticipation for their next show.

Anticipation: Anticipation is a value that represents the crowd's overall enthusiasm and expectations for the PCs' show. The higher the Anticipation, the bigger the PCs' Payout. However, if the PCs generate more Anticipation than the show can satisfy, the show is a failure.

Excitement: Excitement is a value that represents the crowd's satisfaction with the PCs' show. The PCs generate Excitement by successfully completing tricks, and must generate more Excitement than Anticipation in order to earn their full Payout.

Payout: After putting on a show, the PCs earn an amount of money that depends on how their performance went. They can use this money, called Payout, to purchase advertisements, circus upgrades, or new tricks.

Prestige: Prestige is a value that represents the circus company's renown and fame. The default Prestige of the PCs' circus starts at 1. The PCs can increase their Prestige by performing shows or purchasing the spotlights circus upgrade.

Promotion: The PCs can Promote the Circus during the week before they put on a show to generate Anticipation.

Random Events: Before each circus performance, the GM rolls a random event, which may make it more or less difficult to perform certain tricks, increase Excitement or Anticipation, or have some other effect on the upcoming performance.

Tricks: Each circus act consists of one or more tricks, which is circus parlance for a stunt or spectacle. Each performer employed by the circus has one trick, and every trick requires the NPC or PC performing it to attempt at least one trick check (for NPCs, the GM can roll or delegate a player to do so; tricks performed by PCs are also called signature tricks). Succeeding at a trick check generates Excitement, but critically succeeding generates additional Anticipation as well (which may not be desirable because it makes subsequent trick checks more difficult). Critically failing a trick check decreases the show's Excitement value. Each trick also has at least one trick trait associated with it, which can modify how the trick is performed depending on other circumstances such as random events or circus upgrades.

Upgrades: The PCs can purchase circus upgrades to improve aspects of their circus or affect the performance of certain tricks.

Preparing for the Show

Before putting on a show, the PCs must generate interest in their circus and draw a crowd of paying customers. This is represented by Anticipation, a numerical value that the PCs increase during the days leading up to a show. The higher the show's Anticipation, the higher the circus's potential Payout at the end of the show.

GENERATING ANTICIPATION

One of the most important parts of running a circus troupe is getting the word out and drawing in paying audience members. Before the big night, the PCs need to generate Anticipation for their upcoming show. This value represents the audience's expectations and overall enthusiasm for the upcoming performance.

The PCs need to generate Anticipation for every show they put on. Anticipation lasts only 1 week, meaning the PCs have 6 days leading up to a show to build Anticipation. It resets to 0 after each show or 6 days after the first Anticipation is generated (in the event the PCs don't put on a show).

During the week before they put on a show, the PCs can purchase advertisements or Promote the Circus to increase their Anticipation. Purchasing advertisements requires no expenditure of downtime, but must be done at the beginning of the week (before Promoting the Circus) and costs money (either from the circus's Payout funds or the PCs' own wallets); see Purchasing Advertisements below for more details. Promoting the Circus costs nothing, but requires a PC to undertake a downtime activity that takes 2 days.

Maximum Anticipation: The PCs' tent can hold only so many spectators, which limits how much Anticipation the circus can generate for each show. The circus's starting maximum Anticipation is 20. Any Anticipation generated in excess of this (either from downtime, random events, or any other source) is ignored. The circus's maximum Anticipation can be increased by certain upgrades, non-performer roles, or random events.

Purchasing Advertisements

At the beginning of the week preceding a show, the PCs can purchase an advertisement tier, which represents varying levels of advertising, such as posters for a low-level tier, endorsements from town influencers at mid-tier, and even magical billboards at higher tiers. They must do so before they have Promoted the Circus (page 61). The PCs can purchase only one advertising tier per week. Higher-tier advertisements generate more Anticipation but cost more money. Advertisements are good for only one show; after that show, an advertisement tier must be purchased again to generate Anticipation.

The PCs can purchase an advertisement tier using their circus Payout or their own adventuring money (see Earning and Spending Payout on page 67).

TABLE 1: ADVERTISEMENTS AND ANTICIPATION

Tier	Cost	Anticipation
1	1 gp	1
2	5 gp	2
3	20 gp	4
4	40 gp	6
5	80 gp	9
6	150 gp	12
7	250 gp	16
8	500 gp	20
9	800 gp	25
10	1,200 gp	30
11	2,000 gp	40
12	3,000 gp	50

Promoting the Circus

PCs can use the following untrained downtime activity to generate Anticipation for their next show. Only one PC can Promote the Circus at a time (unless that PC is being aided by another PC; see below), meaning the party has three chances to Promote the Circus before each circus show.

PROMOTE THE CIRCUS (SOCIETY)

CIRCUS DOWNTIME

You spend 2 consecutive days in town generating Anticipation for your next circus show. Attempt a Society check. The DC of this check is equal to the DC appropriate for the group's party level; see Table 10–5 on page 503 of the *Pathfinder Core Rulebook*. One other PC can spend 2 downtime days to Aid you, providing a +2 circumstance bonus to your Society check if they succeed at a DC 20 Society check.

Critical Success You generate Anticipation equal to twice the sum of your level plus your Charisma modifier (minimum 2).

Success You generate Anticipation equal to your level plus your Charisma modifier (minimum 1).

Failure You generate 1 Anticipation.

Critical Failure You generate no Anticipation.

PRE-SHOW EXCITEMENT

In addition to generating Anticipation before the next show, the PCs can generate Excitement as well, which is carried into the start of the show and marked in the Starting Excitement box on the Circus Show Sheet. The most common ways of generating pre-show Excitement include circus upgrades and certain random circus events.

Putting on a Show

All of the circus company's hard work and time is put to the test during the night of the big show. The PCs can put on up to one show per week. You as the GM should make clear to the PCs at what points during the campaign they'll have the opportunity to put on a show, so they can plan their downtime accordingly and promote or advertise the show as needed. Generally, the PCs should be allowed to plan and put on performances whenever they are in a settlement or peaceful communal area suitable for gatherings (such as a region of interconnected farms), and they should have 6 days before the show to generate Anticipation and pre-show Excitement.

Some parts of the Extinction Curse Adventure Path preclude circus performances for a significant amount of time; these sections are noted in the adventures' text as they occur, and should be made clear to the PCs as well.

After downtime, during which the PCs generated Anticipation for their show, the time has come to actually perform for an audience. A circus show is divided into four acts: the opener, the build-up, the big number, and the finale. Each act consists of one or more tricks. Each trick involves rolling a trick check. The results of these checks determine how much Excitement is generated. The PCs' goal is to generate more Excitement than the crowd's Anticipation, resulting in a successful show.

The steps for putting on a show, in order, are as follows.

1. Purchase Temporary Upgrades (page 69): The PCs purchase temporary upgrades (if any) for the show.

2. Choose Non-Performer Roles (page 66): The PCs choose which non-performer roles, if any, they will each take during the show. A PC who selects a non-performer role can't perform any tricks during the show.

3. Roll for Random Events (page 66): The GM rolls to determine which random event affects the show.

4. Tally Starting Anticipation (page 60): The GM marks the starting Anticipation for the show (Anticipation may change throughout the show).

5. Perform Acts and Tricks (below): The PCs choose which tricks to perform during each act, then follow the rules for performing tricks until all four acts are over.

6. Calculate Payout (page 67): The GM calculates the PCs' Payout, which depends on the success of the show.

ACTS

Each circus performance consists of four acts composed of a total of seven tricks. The first act is called the opener, and it consists of only one trick to capture the crowd's attention. The build-up involves two tricks to impress the crowd; the big number has just one that's often the focus of the entire evening's show; and the finale has three tricks to present a dazzling spectacle of all the circus offers.

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At the beginning of each act, the PCs choose which trick or tricks to include in that act. They can pick from any that the PCs or their NPC performers know (see Tricks, below). For acts with multiple tricks, the tricks happen concurrently in separate rings, but the PCs take turns describing their performances.

Just like in combat encounters, each performer in an act can use up to 3 actions. At least 1 action must be used to Perform a Trick (page 63); otherwise, each performer can Costar with another performer, Send in the Clowns, Perform their Trick again, or skip their remaining actions.



After each performer has used their actions for the act, the PCs choose the tricks for the next act; they repeat this until they've used their actions for the finale, after which the show is over.

The PCs can choose any combination of tricks for their show, with one major restriction: each trick can be performed only once per show. NPC tricks may have additional restrictions (see Reading NPC Tricks, page 63).

TRICKS

A trick consists of one or more trick checks—this is a skill check, saving throw, or attack roll that represents the performer's feat of grace or strength. PCs attempt trick checks by taking the Perform a Trick action (page 63) while they are onstage during an act. This action may have one or more trick traits associated with it, such as alchemical for tricks with alchemy or musical for tricks that involve songs or sound effects (see Trick Traits on page 63).

Tricks come in two types: NPC tricks and PC tricks (which are also called signature tricks). A performer, whether NPC or PC, can perform only their own trick, although it's possible for a PC to design a signature trick almost identical to an NPC's trick. NPC tricks have different restrictions than PC tricks, but don't scale with their level; that is, a 6th-level NPC trick is always a 6th-level NPC trick. PC tricks, however, grow in level alongside the PC who performs them, and can be modified as the PCs progress through the campaign.

At the beginning of the Extinction Curse Adventure Path, the Circus of Wayward Wonders has six NPC tricks and one signature trick for every PC in the party who wants to create one. A PC's signature trick is of their own design and can't be performed by anyone else. The PCs can hire additional talent as the campaign goes on, gaining access to more traits for their own signature tricks. As the showrunners, the PCs decide which tricks are performed during which acts in each circus show.

NPC Tricks

When an NPC performs their trick, either a player or the GM can roll the trick checks for the NPC, using the DC and the modifiers listed in the trick description. NPCs can't perform other NPCs' tricks, nor can they perform PC tricks. NPC tricks may have any number of trick traits and types of trick checks; these are not limited by their level, as PC tricks are.

New NPC tricks become available to the PCs' circus as the PCs hire additional performers. These NPC tricks might have new trick traits (below), to which the PCs gain access as soon as they hire the NPC.

Reading NPC Tricks: NPC tricks include the name of the trick, the trick's level (and associated DC for the trick check), any traits associated with it, the types of trick checks used to perform the trick, a description of the trick, and additional requirements (if any). NPC tricks appear on the inside covers of each volume of the Extinction Curse Adventure Path.

PC Tricks (Signature Tricks)

Each PC can design their own signature trick. The player decides their signature trick's trick check (which can be a skill check, saving throw, or attack roll), chooses a trick trait (below), and names and dramatically describes the trick. The signature trick's level is equal to the PC's level and increases whenever the PC gains a level. Only the PC who created the signature trick can perform it; NPCs or other PCs cannot perform another PC's signature trick. Otherwise, signature tricks do not have additional requirements or challenges associated with them.

PCs' signature tricks improve and grow more complex as they go up in level, as shown on Table 2: Trick Progression. For example, while a 1st-level performer can use only a single type of check to perform their trick and their trick has only one trick trait, a 10th-level performer can use one of two different checks for each trick attempt and their trick can have up to two trick traits.

Redesigning Tricks: Once a signature trick is created, it is difficult to change. A PC can change their signature trick (including its trick checks and trick traits) whenever they gain a level or by spending 6 consecutive downtime days redesigning the trick.

TABLE 2: TRICK PROGRESSION

Level	Benefits
1	1 trick check, 1 trick trait
4	2 trick checks
8	2 trick traits
12	3 trick traits
16	3 trick checks
20	4 trick traits

Generating Excitement with Tricks

Each PC or NPC performing in a circus act must attempt the following action at least once and up to three times.

PERFORM A TRICK ❖

CIRCUS

You perform your signature circus trick. Attempt one of the trick checks associated with your trick. The DC for the trick check is determined by your level, as shown on Table 10–5 on page 503 of the *Core Rulebook*. The result of each trick check determines whether you generate Excitement, generate Excitement and Anticipation, or lose Excitement.

Critical Success You generate Excitement equal to the trick's level; this Excitement is added to the circus's total Excitement for the show. You also generate Anticipation equal to half the trick's level (rounded up); this Anticipation is added to the circus's total Anticipation for the show.

Success You generate Excitement equal to the trick's level; this Excitement is added to the circus's total Excitement for the show.

Failure No effect.

Critical Failure The circus's Excitement value decreases by a value equal to half the trick's level (rounded up).

You can Perform a Trick multiple times per act, and can choose a different possible trick check for each attempt. If you Perform a Trick twice during the same act, you take a –5 penalty to your second trick check. If you Perform a Trick three times, the penalty for the third check is –10. (This is similar to how the multiple attack penalty works; see page 446 of the *Core Rulebook*.) The penalties are reduced to –4 and –8, respectively, if your trick has the agile trait.

This action always has the circus trait. Starting at 1st level, you can choose one additional trick trait you have access to for your signature trick, and apply it to this action as well. You can add additional traits as your level increases (see Table 2: Trick Progression).

For example, a 3rd-level trick generates 3 Excitement with each successful trick check, 3 Excitement and 2 Anticipation for each critical success, and –2 Excitement for each critical failure. Other factors, such as the trick's traits, the PCs' purchased circus upgrades, or other circus roles (page 66) may alter the amount of Excitement generated by certain tricks.

Trick Traits

The Perform a Trick action can have one or more special traits associated with it. These traits tie into other circus rules, such as random events, non-performer roles, or purchased upgrades. Some of these traits share names with other traits found in the *Core Rulebook*, but have different rules associated with them in the context of these circus rules.

Starting at 1st level, each PC can add one trick trait to their signature trick. This trait must be chosen when the trick is first designed or when the PC changes their signature trick after gaining a level, retraining, or redesigning the trick. A PC must have access to a trait to add it to their signature trick; to gain access to a trait, the circus must have hired an NPC performer whose trick includes that trait. For example, a PC can't add the alchemical trait to their signature trick until an NPC whose trick has the alchemical trait joins the circus.

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A PC can add additional trick traits to their signature trick by taking the Advanced Circus Trick general feat. See the *Extinction Curse Player's Guide* for more details.

The following are descriptions of every trick trait. At the start of the Extinction Curse Adventure Path, the PCs have access to the following traits: agile, animal, fire, and water. More traits become available to the PCs as they hire additional NPC performers.

If a trick trait's name is followed by the name of a skill in parentheses, then a performer gains a +1 circumstance bonus to Perform a Trick with that trait using that skill check. For example, a performer whose trick has the aerial trick trait gains a +1 circumstance bonus to Acrobatics trick checks.

Some traits are compulsory, meaning that if a signature trick meets certain criteria then that trick must have the indicated trait. For example, any signature trick that uses a saving throw for one of its trick checks must have the injury trait. These compulsory trick traits do not count toward a signature trick's maximum number of traits. Compulsory trick traits are marked with an asterisk (*).

Aerial (Acrobatics): The trick involves flight by either magical or mundane means.

Air (Survival): The trick involves the manipulation of mist, wind, or another prop with atmospheric properties.



Alchemical: As part of the trick, the performer can expend one alchemical item in their possession. Upon doing so, the performer gains a +1 circumstance bonus to their trick check. This destroys the item.

Agile: The penalty for performing an agile trick a second or third time in the same act is –4 or –8, respectively, instead of –5 or –10.

Animal (Nature): The trick utilizes trained animals.

Audience (Society): The audience participates in the trick.

Beast (Arcana): The trick relies on intelligent beasts.

Dance: The trick involves dancing or choreographed movements. Circumstance bonuses to trick checks gained from performers using the Costar reaction (page 65) stack. For example, if two other PCs successfully Costar with their ally and have the master proficiency rank in that trick check, the total circumstance bonus granted from the Costar reaction is +6 (rather than +3).

Earth (Occultism): The trick involves the use of mud, earth, or stone.

Emotion: The trick uses alchemical or magical effects to induce a powerful emotional response from the audience. A trick must have either the alchemical or magical trait in order to have the emotion trait. Whenever a performer succeeds or critically succeeds at a trick check with the emotion trait, they can reduce the amount of Excitement or Anticipation (or both) the trick generates however they wish, down to a minimum of 0 Excitement or Anticipation.

Fire (Intimidation): This trick involves fire, smoke, or pyrotechnics.

Injury*: Anytime a PC uses a saving throw for one of the trick checks, the trick has this trait. If an NPC or PC performing a trick with the injury trait critically fails any trick check, they have a chance of becoming injured. To determine if the performer is injured, roll a flat DC 15 check. On a failure, the performer becomes injured. An injured performer (whether PC or NPC) cannot perform tricks for the rest of the show. In addition, at the beginning of the next show, the injured performer must succeed at a flat DC 15 check to determine if they have recovered sufficiently to perform again. On a failure, the performer cannot perform in that show, either due

to the lasting effects of the injury or due to fright of becoming injured again. A performer can miss only one show after the show in which they were injured. On subsequent shows, no check is necessary and the PC or NPC can once again perform as normal.

Magical: The trick involves the use of magic. While Performing the Trick, the performer can expend one spell slot of any level. If the performance succeeds or critically succeeds, the trick generates an additional amount of Excitement equal to the expended spell slot's level.

Musical (Performance): The trick involves musical cues or is somehow augmented by sound effects or music.

Plant (Nature): The trick uses plants such as trees, flowers, or fungi, or uses magic that affects such plants.

Prop (Crafting): The trick requires the use of some mundane prop or stage setup.

Team*: This trick requires more than one person. Anytime a PC performing a signature trick accepts the Costar reaction from a performer, the trick has this trait.

Time: The trick involves distorting or altering time in some way. A performer whose trick has the time trait can perform that trick one additional time per act, taking a penalty to the fourth trick check equal to the penalty to the third trick check.

Water (Athletics): The trick features water as a primary component of its performance.

OTHER SHOW ACTIONS

In addition to Perform a Trick, PCs can perform the following action and reaction during their turn in the ring. A PC must be performing in an act to do so and must use the indicated number of actions.

COSTAR ↷

CIRCUS

Trigger Another performer in the same act as you is about to attempt a trick check.

Requirements The performer is willing to accept your aid.

You help another performer in the act pull off their trick, possibly granting them a bonus to the triggering trick check. Attempt the same check as the trick check you are attempting to aid. The DC to Costar is equal to the DC of the trick check. NPCs cannot Costar. This reaction otherwise acts as the Aid action described on page 470 of the *Core Rulebook*.

SEND IN THE CLOWNS ❖

CIRCUS

Requirements You or another performer has failed or critically failed a trick check during the current act.

You give the signal for the circus's clown troupe to come onstage and rescue a botched trick. A failed trick becomes a success instead, or if it was a critical failure, it is instead a failure. The clowns can be sent in only once per act, and only one trick check is affected.

EXAMPLE OF AN ACT WITH TWO TRICKS

For the second act of this week's circus show, the build-up, Gerard the rogue is attempting his signature trick, the Deep-Sea Dunk, which involves shackling his hands together before he is dropped in a water tank from which he must escape. Performing alongside him in the other ring is Janelle the ranger, who will be performing as the Incredible Manticore Tamer (with some help from her lion animal companion in costume).

Because he is a 4th-level PC, Gerard's trick can have one trick trait and he can choose from one of two different trick checks whenever he performs the Deep-Sea Dunk. When he last leveled up, Gerard chose the agile trait for his trick and decided his available trick checks would be a Thievery check (representing his ability to undo his manacles) and a Fortitude saving throw (representing his ability to hold his breath).

Janelle, also 4th level, has chosen the animal trait for her trick, and uses either Nature or Intimidation for her trick checks (representing her ability to keep her animal under control and her ability to scare the audience with her stunt, respectively).

The group decides that Gerard will describe his performance and take his actions first. Gerard describes his trick—the trapdoor drops, he plunges into the tank of water!—and rolls a Thievery trick check for his first action. Including his check modifier, his result is 26, which handily overcomes the DC of 19 for 4th-level characters and generates 4 Excitement. He decides to attempt two more trick checks, this time Fortitude saves to hold his breath, taking the –4 and –8 penalties on his rolls (because his trick has the agile trait) and getting results of 20 (just beating the DC) and 9 (a critical failure). His second roll generates 4 Excitement, but his last roll, a critical failure, subtracts 2 Excitement from the circus's running total. Because his critically failed trick check was a saving throw, Gerard must also attempt a DC 15 flat check to determine if he is injured as a result of his trick. Thankfully he rolls a 16, allowing him to avoid injury.

Janelle attempts a Nature trick check for her first action, and her result is a 29—a critical success! She generates 4 Excitement but also 2 Anticipation. She decides to attempt another Nature trick check for her second action but gets only a 17—a failure. For her last action, she Sends in the Clowns, changing her failed trick check to a success instead and generating a total of 8 Excitement and 2 Anticipation from her performance.

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NON-PERFORMER ROLES

Of course, some PCs might not want to perform in every circus show their troupe puts on. In this case, PCs can take part in auxiliary roles that, while not the focus of the show, can still play a big part in the circus's success.

Each of the following non-performer roles requires a PC to abstain from performing in the show but grants a bonus to various parts of the performance. NPCs cannot perform these roles; it is assumed that they are fully occupied with preparing for their acts. Once chosen, a non-performer role cannot be changed until the next show. Only one PC can perform a particular non-performer role per show (for example, two PCs can't both choose the role of animal handler). Some roles can be chosen only after purchasing certain circus upgrades.

The GM can create additional non-performer roles for the PCs, using the roles listed here as baselines.

Animal Handler: Trick checks with the animal trait gain a +2 circumstance bonus, and a PC whose signature trick has the animal trait can perform twice in the same show (though not in the same act). If the animals break loose event is rolled on Table 3: Random Circus Events (below), reroll on that table instead.

Backup Clown: Performers can Send in the Clowns one additional time per act.

Bandleader: After each trick is completed, the bandleader can choose to generate Anticipation equal to half the bandleader's level rounded up. The circus must have the acoustics permanent upgrade (page 69) before a PC can choose the bandleader role.

Carnival Barker: The carnival barker draws in more audience members as the show goes on and increases the show's maximum Anticipation. For every successful trick check performed, the carnival barker can choose to increase the show's maximum Anticipation by 5.

Clown Coordinator: You can Send in the Clowns as a reaction instead of using 1 action.

Costumer: Performers get a +1 circumstance bonus to trick checks with the audience trait.

Lighting: Performers gain a +1 circumstance bonus to Deception and Thievery trick checks. The circus must have the spotlights permanent upgrade before a PC can choose the lighting role.

Medic: Performers can't become injured from critically failing tricks with the injury trait.

Pyrotechnic: Trick checks with the fire trait generate double Excitement.

Security Guard: Any rolls of hecklers or scalpers on Table 3: Random Circus Events are negated and have no effect on the performance.

RANDOM CIRCUS EVENTS

It's impossible to account for every possibility before the curtains go up and the show starts. At the beginning of each circus show, roll a d12 and refer to the following table to determine which random event takes place. The GM can create additional random events, using the following events as baselines.

TABLE 3: RANDOM CIRCUS EVENTS

D12	Event
1	Animals break loose
2	Bad weather
3	Clown lung
4	Equipment malfunction
5	Food poisoning
6	Hecklers
7	Injured performer
8	Overflowing crowd
9	Scalpers
10	Stars align
11	Tent breaks
12	Roll again twice (reroll subsequent 12s)

Animals Break Loose: Animal tricks can't be performed during the show, and the crowd's Excitement and Anticipation each increase by 2d6 (rolled separately).

Bad Weather: Trick checks with the aerial or fire trait take a –2 circumstance penalty and trick checks with the earth trait gain a +2 circumstance bonus. If the show is a success, the Payout is doubled.

Clown Lung: Performers cannot Send in the Clowns unless a PC takes the backup clown non-performer role.

Equipment Malfunction: The NPC with the highest trick level (chosen randomly in the case of a tie) cannot perform in the show.

Food Poisoning: Trick checks take a –1 circumstance penalty. The GM randomly selects two trick traits; trick checks with those traits take a –2 circumstance penalty.

Hecklers: During each act, one performer (chosen randomly for acts with more than one performer, after the PCs have selected which tricks will be performed) takes a –1 circumstance penalty to trick checks.

Injured Performer: One of the PCs (chosen randomly) cannot perform during this show. The PC can still take on a non-performer role.

Overflowing Crowd: The crowd's starting Anticipation increases by 4d6 and the maximum Anticipation limit for the show increases by 20.

Scalpers: The PCs' Prestige (page 67) is treated as 3 less (minimum 1) when calculating Payout.

Stars Align: Trick check DCs decrease by 2.

Tent Breaks: The circus's maximum Anticipation for the show decreases by 10.

Payout and Prestige

For each show the PCs put on, they'll earn fame and increase the wealth in their coffers. Payout is the PCs' earnings, which they can use to upgrade their circus facilities, hire new talent, or purchase advertisements. Prestige represents the circus's overall renown and the influence it has in towns where it performs.

DEGREES OF SUCCESS

The circus's show can be either a critical success, a success, or a failure. If the PCs generate more Excitement than Anticipation, the show is a success. If they generate less Excitement than Anticipation, the show is a failure.

A critically successful show is much more difficult to achieve than other critical successes in Pathfinder: in order to put on a critically successful show, the PCs must generate exactly as much Excitement as Anticipation.

EARNING AND SPENDING PAYOUT

At the end of a successful performance, the PCs earn an amount of Payout, which is calculated using the following formula. (Note that the PCs earn Payout before earning Prestige, so they use the Prestige value they had when they performed the show, not their new Prestige value after the show.)

(Prestige + Final Anticipation) = Payout (in gp)

If the show was a critical success, the Payout is doubled. This doubling stacks with the increase granted by the bad weather event (see opposite page), in which case the Payout is effectively quadrupled.

If the PCs fail to generate more Excitement than Anticipation, their show is a failure. Calculate Payout using Excitement instead of Anticipation, then multiply the final amount by one-quarter (rounded down). The formula is as follows, instead.

(Prestige + Final Excitement) × 1/4 = Payout (in gp)

For example, if the PCs' circus has a Prestige of 3 and they perform a successful show with 20 Anticipation, then they would earn 23 gp as their Payout (3 + 20 = 23 gp). However, if they generated only 15 Excitement during the show and thus their performance was a failure, they would earn only 4 gp instead (3 + 15 = 18, and 18 × 1/4 = 4.5 gp).

The circus always earns enough money to cover its baseline expenses and pay its employees; Payout represents profit in excess of this baseline. Payout can be used only for circus-related expenses (the PCs cannot use their profits from the circus to fund their adventures, for example).

SIMPLIFIED CIRCUS RULES

Your group might not have the time or might simply not be interested in running a full-fledged circus operation between adventures. The Extinction Curse Adventure Path can be run entirely without the PCs' involvement in the Circus of Wayward Wonders. Alternatively, your group can use the following guidelines to run simplified circus shows.

Ignore the Anticipation and Excitement rules; instead, use a simple Performance check for each act. During a show, each PC can attempt one Performance check (or other relevant skill check, at your discretion) to determine the success or failure of each act. The DC for this check is equal to the appropriate DC for that PC's level (see Table 10–5 on page 503 of the *Core Rulebook*). The PCs can attempt more difficult tricks by modifying the DC (as shown on Table 10–6 on page 504 of the *Core Rulebook*); for each step above the standard DC attempted, the trick counts as one more trick for the purpose of tallying the PCs' failed versus successful tricks (a very hard trick, for example, would count as three successful tricks on a successful Performance check or three failed tricks on a failed check).

The show is successful if the PCs succeed at as least as many Performance checks as they fail. Ignore the rules for Payout but tally Prestige as normal, since the party's Prestige may still affect other aspects of the campaign.

If you use this system, be sure to encourage roleplaying and give the PCs bonuses to their rolls if they describe their acts creatively. You may also still want to incorporate random circus events (page 66) to prevent the performances from becoming predictable. Either way, be sure to go into detail describing the audience's reactions and the town's overall enthusiasm toward the PCs' troupe, since this system will make for very quick circus shows.

EARNING PRESTIGE

The circus starts with a Prestige of 1, which the PCs increase by performing shows. After a failed show, the circus earns 1 Prestige. If the show was a success, then the circus earns 2 Prestige instead, or 4 Prestige if the show was a critical success. Some circus upgrades (page 69) require the circus to have a minimum Prestige before they can be purchased.

In addition to its use in the circus rules in this article, the circus's Prestige will factor into several rewards and events throughout the Extinction Curse Adventure Path. These rewards and events are always optional, but may help the PCs in their quest to save the Isle of Kortos.

THE SHOW MUST GO ON
Chapter 1: Murder in the Center Ring
Chapter 2: Abberton Investigations
Chapter 3: The Corrupted Hermitage
Chapter 4: Xulgaths in the Tower
Life in the Circus
Adventure Toolbox

CIRCUS SHOW SHEET

Circus Name _____ Date _____

Settlement Name _____

Downtime

Advertisement Tier _____ gp _____ ANT _____

Downtime Activities

Day 1	ANT
Day 2	ANT
Day 3	ANT
Day 4	ANT
Day 5	ANT
Day 6	ANT

STARTING STATS

Prestige

Excitement (EXC)

Anticipation (ANT)

Max ANT

Showtime

TEMPORARY UPGRADES

- ☐ Beer
- ☐ Confections
- ☐ Disposable Binoculars
- Merchandise
  - ☐ Basic
  - ☐ Quality
  - ☐ Extraordinary
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____

NON-PERFORMER ROLES

PC	Role

Random Event

ACT 1: OPENER

Trick 1

Performer _____ Level _____ Trick DC _____

Action	(Result)	EXC	ANT

ACT 2: BUILD-UP

Trick 2

Performer _____ Level _____ Trick DC _____

Action	(Result)	EXC	ANT

Trick 3

Performer _____ Level _____ Trick DC _____

Action	(Result)	EXC	ANT

ACT 3: BIG NUMBER

Trick 4

Performer _____ Level _____ Trick DC _____

Action	(Result)	EXC	ANT

ACT 4: FINALE

Trick 5

Performer _____ Level _____ Trick DC _____

Action	(Result)	EXC	ANT

Trick 6

Performer _____ Level _____ Trick DC _____

Action	(Result)	EXC	ANT

Trick 7

Performer _____ Level _____ Trick DC _____

Action	(Result)	EXC	ANT

PAYOUT

Final EXC

Final ANT

Prestige

Total Payout

CIRCUS UPGRADES

The PCs can upgrade their circus anytime between shows. Each upgrade has a price; the PCs can pay for the upgrade using either Payout or their own personal funds.

Two types of upgrades can be purchased: permanent upgrades and temporary upgrades. Permanent upgrades, once purchased, affect every show thereafter. Temporary upgrades can be purchased on a per-show basis; a temporary upgrade affects only the next show, and each temporary upgrade can be purchased only once per show. Some upgrades grant access to certain non-performer roles (page 66). Additional upgrades may become available throughout the Extinction Curse Adventure Path.

Certain upgrades can be purchased only after the PCs have purchased a preceding upgrade, such as the huge and massive tent size increases. These upgrades are indented on Table 4: Circus Upgrades, and must be purchased in the order presented.

TABLE 4: CIRCUS UPGRADES

Permanent Upgrades		
Upgrade	**Price**	**Min. Prestige**
Acoustics	30 gp	5
Flooring		
Safety net	20 gp	–
Padded floors	100 gp	6
Seating		
Bleachers	50 gp	5
Assigned seats	100 gp	10
Upholstered seats	250 gp	15
Spotlights	40 gp	4
Tent Expansions		
Big	40 gp	3
Huge	100 gp	10
Massive	300 gp	15
Watermarked tickets	50 gp	–
Temporary Upgrades		
Upgrade	**Price**	**Min. Prestige**
Beer	5 gp	–
Confections	15 gp	5
Disposable binoculars	25 gp	8
Merchandise, basic	20 gp	3
Merchandise, quality	40 gp	6
Merchandise, extraordinary	60 gp	10

Permanent Upgrade Descriptions

Permanent upgrades can be purchased only once, and convey their benefits to every circus show thereafter.

Acoustics: PCs and NPCs gain a +1 circumstance bonus to trick checks with the musical trait. After purchasing this upgrade, the bandleader role becomes available to PCs.

Flooring: Performers whose tricks have the injury trait are at a lower risk of getting hurt after a critically failed trick check. With a safety net, the DC of the flat checks to determine if a performer becomes injured or can perform at the next show decreases to 10. With padded floors, the flat check DC decreases to 5.

Seating: Quality seating options generate additional Excitement for the circus's shows but reduce the circus's maximum Anticipation by 10. At the start of each show, a circus with bleachers generates 5 Excitement. A circus with assigned seats generates 10 Excitement instead, and upholstered seats instead generate 20 Excitement.

Spotlights: This upgrade grants a permanent +1 increase to the circus's Prestige. In addition, after purchasing this upgrade, a PC can choose the lighting role during circus shows.

Tent Expansions: Bigger tents increase the circus's maximum Anticipation limit. A big tent increases the circus's maximum Anticipation to 50, a huge tent increases the Anticipation limit to 100, and a massive tent increases the Anticipation limit to 200.

Watermarked Tickets: An intricate ticket design makes forgeries near impossible, reducing sales of counterfeit tickets. For the purpose of calculating Payout, the circus's Prestige is treated as 2 points higher than it actually is.

Temporary Upgrade Descriptions

Each temporary upgrade can be purchased only once before each show. A temporary upgrade affects only the next show.

Beer: The circus generates an additional 2d6 Anticipation for the next show, and tricks with the audience trait gain a +2 circumstance bonus. However, the hecklers event (page 66) is automatically triggered, in addition to any other random event rolled.

Confections: The circus generates an additional 2d6 Excitement at the start of the next show.

Disposable Binoculars: There is no maximum Anticipation limit for the next show.

Merchandise: This temporary upgrade has no effect on the next show; instead, a fraction of the final Anticipation total of the next show is carried on to the show after that. With basic merchandise, the circus retains 25% of its final Anticipation (rounded down). This amount is instead 50% with quality merchandise, or 75% with extraordinary merchandise. This upgrade cannot be purchased for two shows in a row (that is, it cannot "stack" with itself).

For example, if this upgrade were purchased for a show that ultimately generated a final Anticipation of 20, then the show after that would start with an additional 5, 10, or 15 Anticipation (for basic, quality, or extraordinary merchandise, respectively).